

If you've ever been on Reddit, you'd know that this is the perfect time for...a plot twist. So, here it is – almost everything that you've learnt until now is closely related to XUL. How's that? Well, all the manifest, and mostly all of the other specification files and declarations that we've been talking about are intrinsically tied to XUL in their understanding and implementation.

For quick reference (since we'll need to remember this later) here are some key features and benefits of XUL.

KEY FEATURES AND BENEFITS

Powerful widget-based markup language

The goal of XUL is to build cross-platform applications, in contrast to DHTML which is intended for developing web pages. For this reason, XUL is oriented toward application artifacts such as windows, labels and buttons instead of pages, heading levels and hypertext links.

In fact, many developers invest a significant amount of effort to achieve these results in their DHTML web applications but at the cost of complexity and performance and without any supporting standards.

Based on existing standards

XUL is an XML language based on W3C standard XML 1.0. Applications written in XUL are based on additional W3C standard technologies featuring HTML 4.0; Cascading Style Sheets (CSS) 1 and 2; Document Object Model (DOM) Levels 1 and 2; JavaScript 1.5, including ECMA-262 Edition 3 (ECMAScript) and XML 1.0.

Mozilla.org is going a step further by seeking W3C standardisation for the eXtensible Binding Language (XBL).

Platform portability

Like HTML, XUL is designed to be platform-neutral, making applications easily portable to all of the operating systems on which Mozilla runs. Considering the broad range of platforms that currently support Mozilla, this may be one of the most compelling features of XUL as a technology for building applications.

Since XUL provides an abstraction of user interface components, it delivers on the promise of "write once, run anywhere". The user interface for all of Mozilla's core applications (Browser, Messenger, Address Book, etc.) is written in XUL with one single code base supporting all Mozilla platforms.